factory-produced junk.' What he wanted was a level-playing field. 'India can be essentially only built by Indians,' said Gurumurthy. 'But whenever someone from London comes to FIPB [Foreign Investment Promotion Board], he is given undue respect while Indians are not even treated professionally. It is our duty to protect Indian companies.' He also drew a sharp distinction between the BJP, the RSS and SJM. In his view, while the BJP looked to address current economic issues, 'we [the RSS and SJM] look at economic issues from a 25-year point of view. The BJP has to temper the current trends from the standpoint of wider national interest.'[95]

This background of contesting ideas from the 1990s has provided the subtext to Prime Minister Modi's economic outlook. So, even as he sought to position India as a competitive destination for foreign investments as part of economic diplomacy during foreign tours and liberalised the FDI regime in several sectors, his government became focused on the idea of AatmaNirbhar Bharat. On balance, 'if self-image is any indication', the BJP has 'consciously shied away from projecting itself as a party of the Right', argued BJP MP Swapan Dasgupta in 2020. This reluctance also stems from how the BJP interpreted the political impact of Vajpayee's economic policies between 1999 and 2004. 'Atal Bihari Vajpayee, never very comfortable with questions centred on the economy, always saw the Jana Sangh/BJP as a party of the Centre,' wrote Dasgupta. 'Despite this ideological baggage, the Vajpayee government did take certain decisive steps that identified it with the conventional Right globally.'[96] These steps, like disinvestment, did not go down well with a large section of the Sangh Parivar, and after the BJP lost the 2004 general election, 'the party's internal assessment blamed the Vajpayee Government's privatisation policy for leaving the BJP's middle-class supporters dispirited.'[97]

Modinomics: What the Government Says and What It Has Done

Word View: Key Words that Define Modi-era Budgets